

1. State your research question and/or project goal.

My research will focus on how the algorithm acts as a gatekeeper to new creators over time. Furthermore, I will examine how the pressure of this algorithm changes the way that individuals view themselves and their art. Lastly, I will investigate whether there is a rights-based model that can assist in determining what social media platforms are to the people who create the content.

2. Describe three key studies that have informed your understanding of the scholarly conversation surrounding your topic.

- Gillespie (2014) investigated how algorithms act as gatekeepers and how platforms often claim that these algorithms are objective. However, users of these platforms are unaware of how much the content they view is pre-processed to ensure that their content is filtered to only those who are most likely to like their content.
- Noble (2018) examined how search engine algorithms lead to the reinforcement of existing racial inequalities. For example, searching for content about Black women and girls led to content that was exploitative of those groups.
- Bucher (2012) interviewed a variety of social media users to determine that these users began to feel anxious with the knowledge that the algorithms were potentially limiting their visibility online. As a result, they began to change the way in which they posted on social media to ensure that they had an audience.

3. Identify the gap addressed by your proposed research, and explain how the gap is situated into the scholarly conversation. Provide sources to justify the gap your proposed research is addressing.

The current scholarly conversation regarding algorithms and social media has mainly focused upon proving that algorithms act as gatekeepers for new creators. Additionally, it has been established that algorithms can create unequal viewing of creators and result in feelings of anxiety among those creators. However, the scholarly conversation has yet to explore the impact of this on brand-new creators who utilize their art as a means of establishing their personal creative identities. Additionally, it would be interesting to explore whether social media platforms have a responsibility to create a rights-based model for creators to ensure that they are provided with access to these platforms.

4. Describe your chosen or developed research method and defend its alignment with your research question.

The research method that I will use for this project will be qualitative interviews and surveys of small creators who utilize various social media platforms to distribute their art. This will enable me to gather information directly from the creators of these art projects, which will allow me to determine at what point they became aware of how the algorithm potentially limited their views, and what changes to their art they made in response to these limitations.

5. Identify additional approval processes (check all that apply):

☒ Human subjects [requires additional IRB review and approval if student wants to publish and/ or publicly present]

☐ Animal subjects [requires additional review or approval by school or district processes]

☐ Harmful microorganisms [requires additional review or approval by school or district processes]

☐ Hazardous materials [requires additional review or approval by school or district processes]

☐ No additional review or approvals required

6. Explain how your proposed method complies with ethical research practices.

I will be interviewing people to obtain their responses about their own channel. Each individual will have to sign a consent form to contribute to the project. The responses will remain anonymous to ensure that the creators behind the channels cannot be identified using the collected data.

7. Describe the data or additional scholarly work that will be generated to answer your proposed research question or achieve your project goal.

The data that will be generated will be from the interview and the survey responses. These will provide insight into the slow change that occurs within artists over time due to adapting to the music streaming platform. Many artists notice a significant drop in their number of views from 8,000 to 1,500 when they are ranked within the platform rankings. This forces these artists to focus on generating more engagement with their content rather than dedicating their efforts to producing high-quality art.

8. Describe the way you will analyze the data or additional scholarly work generated by your method and justify its alignment with your research question or project goal.

The interview data will be analyzed through the use of thematic coding to understand how the platform algorithm dictates the artist's relationship with their audience.

Additionally, I will categorize the answers to determine how their feelings and responses relate to their own identity within the art world and the consequences of being excluded from it altogether.

9. List any equipment, resources, and permissions needed to collect data or information. Attach the initial drafts that apply to your proposal if engaged in human subject research: informed consent forms; surveys, interview questions, questionnaires, or other data gathering forms; or letters/flyers that will be distributed to study subjects.

The research will use google forms or a personalized survey website to gather the survey responses. Additionally, permission will be required to enter the online communities that contain the artists that I would like to interview. Furthermore, the drafted consent forms and interview questions will be required for the research project.

10. Describe the anticipated logistical and personnel challenges for your research project (to collect and analyze data or to pursue research methods appropriate to a paper that supports a performance/exhibit/product).

Beyond finding creators who admitted to changing their art to receive more views, I must also find these creators. The algorithm makes finding these creators even more difficult. These new and small creators will have to be dug up from various message boards and forums online to find any who may be willing to participate in my study. Furthermore, I will have to work to ensure that my assumptions regarding their work and art do not influence the interview results.

11. Provide a brief timeline that outlines your process from now through project completion.

Week 1 will be dedicated to finishing the literature review. Then I will begin to contact the creators for the surveys and interviews.

Week 2 will be dedicated to the interviews and the survey closeout. I will apply the qualitative data to determine the major themes from their answers regarding the need to create engagement with their audiences.

Week 3 will be dedicated to writing and preparing my presentation for the class. This will include discussing the rights-based paradigm for creators.

12. Discuss the anticipated value and/or broader implications of your research project.

I believe that the algorithm is the reason for many of the problems that exist in the present day. From science denial to political extremism, the algorithm only presents information that reflects the views of the individuals consuming the data. Therefore, everyone in an individual's life will have the same views. It is almost treasonous to present information that contradicts what everyone else around the individual believes.

The purpose of this research will be to explain how misinformation is spread so quickly online by those creators. This research can help to develop ways to fix the dialogue within our communities.

Teacher's feedback:

Teacher's Approval (signature):